

Becoming an Effective Teacher

Unit 1 asked what a profession is. Unit 2 asked what it obliges you to do. This unit asks the question those two lead to: what actually makes a teacher good at the work?

It is a harder question than it sounds, and the honest answer begins with a warning. There is no single agreed definition of an effective teacher, and the definitions in use disagree with each other in ways that matter. A teacher judged effective by one measure can be judged ineffective by another, on the same evidence. This unit gives you the competing accounts rather than a tidy one, because a trainee who leaves with a tidy one will be surprised by the first appraisal they sit.

What the unit does offer is a set of components you can observe, and four things that carry effectiveness in practice: the qualities you bring, the relationships you build, the way you communicate, and the roles you take on.

Unit learning outcomes

By the end of this unit you should be able to:

- Explain what **teacher effectiveness** means, describe at least two competing conceptions of it, and say what each captures and misses.
- Name the components used to evaluate teacher effectiveness and distinguish within-classroom processes from factors beyond the classroom.
- Describe the personal and professional qualities associated with effective teaching, including attitude toward the profession and professional image, and explain how a trait can help or harm depending on degree.
- Build and describe positive relationships with pupils, parents, colleagues and the community, and set out a defensible sequence for handling conflict

without losing professionalism.

- Distinguish **verbal** and **non-verbal communication**, name the types of non-verbal channel and their classroom use, and explain what happens when the two channels contradict each other.
- Explain the evolving roles of the teacher as facilitator, researcher, change agent, moral agent and life-long learner, and give a concrete classroom act that expresses each.

Prerequisite knowledge

Units 1 and 2. Unit 1 supplies the idea of professionalism and its dimensions. Unit 2 supplies the ethical obligations that constrain what "effective" is permitted to mean, and that constraint runs through this whole unit: a method that raises marks and damages pupils is not effective teaching, it is a different thing wearing its name.

In this unit

1. **Topic 3.1 - What "an effective teacher" actually means** - the competing definitions, why they disagree, and the components used to evaluate effectiveness.
2. **Topic 3.2 - The qualities an effective teacher brings** - attitude toward the profession, professional image, the named personality traits and how each fails when overdone.
3. **Topic 3.3 - Relationships, and what to do when they go wrong** - the stakeholder web around a teacher, and a workable sequence for conflict.
4. **Topic 3.4 - Saying it so it lands** - verbal and non-verbal communication, the types of non-verbal channel, and what learners do when the channels disagree.
5. **Topic 3.5 - The roles a teacher now has to play** - facilitator, researcher, change agent, moral agent and life-long learner.

How to use this unit

Work through the topics in order. Topic 3.1 sets up a distinction the other four keep using: the difference between what is measured and what is meant.

Topics 3.2 and 3.4 both ask you to look at yourself, and both are more useful done with someone who has seen you teach. If you are on practicum, save the transfer tasks in those two topics for a week when you have a mentor available.

The question bank at the end covers all five topics. Its answers and mark schemes are in a clearly marked section at the foot of that page.

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